



LEFT ISN'T RIGHT: Karat finds it tough to rein in Achuthanandan (second from left) and Vijayan (right)

Comrades At War

In an unprecedented step, the CPI(M) suspends Achuthanandan and Vijayan from the politburo but allows them to continue in office. The harsh penalty is not likely to put an end to their sniping.

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Unprecedented is a word that comes easily to hacks. Now even comrades who attend the normally sombre meetings of the CPI(M) politburo are getting used to it. Last year, the apparatchiks sitting in A.K.G. Bhavan in Gole Market in the heart of the national Capital had to resort to taking "unprecedented" decisions twice. In May 2006, after the denial of an election ticket to the then opposition leader V.S. Achuthanandan led to public outrage that could easily have dented the CPI(M)'s chances in the Assembly elections, the politburo stepped in and reversed the party state

committee's decision that had kept him out of the electoral fray. He contested, won handsomely and was anointed chief minister.

Last week, another unprecedented edict came out of A.K.G. Bhavan. The politburo suspended the chief minister and his long-time rival, the party's state secretary Pinarayi Vijayan, from their memberships of the apex body for giving their dirty linen a public wash. Strange as it may seem, the two were allowed to continue in their official posts—

Achuthanandan as chief minister and Vijayan as state secretary.

To understand how bizarre the situation is, imagine a minister in the UPA Government at the Centre who is constantly critical of the Government. The Congress leadership suspends the minister from a party policy-making body but allows him to continue as minister.

It is such ludicrous dramatics that has characterised the politics of the CPI(M) in Kerala for nearly a decade. After taking over power last

The inner party feuds are largely because of the steep erosion in the central leadership's moral authority.